



WEBSITE REVIEW & REDESIGN

Selvana *Essam*

What wasn't working on [selvana.art](#), who reviewed it and what each of them looked for, and what was changed as a result.

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Beautiful, but it *made people wait* to understand her.

The current site has real taste. The stage photo is unforgettable and the project pages show how she thinks. But a visitor needs about ten seconds and several scrolls to learn what she does, the best proof of her work is hidden, and nothing invites them to get in touch.

7 / 10

Does the idea get across?

Mostly yes, but slowly. After about ten seconds a visitor understands she is a creative director from Alexandria who does art direction, branding and set design, with an elegant, theatrical taste.

What doesn't come across quickly is **what she can do for me** and **why I should contact her now**. A brand owner thinks "beautiful" and leaves without a reason to reach out.

14–17 MB

Homepage weight on the current site, measured on two visits. The new homepage is about 0.5 MB on the first screen.

9

Specialist roles reviewed the site in two rounds: five on how it's built and four on how people take it in.

4 of 4

Reviewers in the second round first read the stage photo as "a performer", before a creative director.

WHAT THE REDESIGN DOES

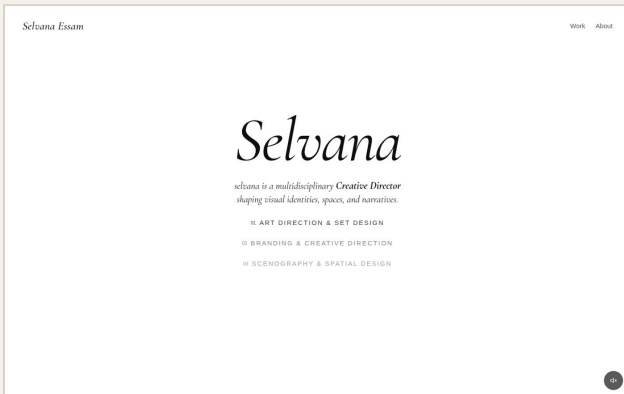
- Says who she is, what she does, for whom and for which clients on the first screen.
- Leads with built, paid work: COLT Coffee, Closer, LAVERN.
- Shows proof on every project: client, city, year and whether it was built.
- Makes contact easy everywhere, especially WhatsApp.
- Loads fast on Egyptian mobile data and works for everyone, including keyboard and screen-reader users.

WHAT STAYS

- The theatre: the stage, the velvet curtain and the spotlight are her signature. They now *introduce* the work instead of standing in front of it.
- The calm, editorial look, with very little text.
- Her own words, projects and photographs. Nothing was invented. Facts that still need confirming are clearly marked.

What works, and what *gets in the way*

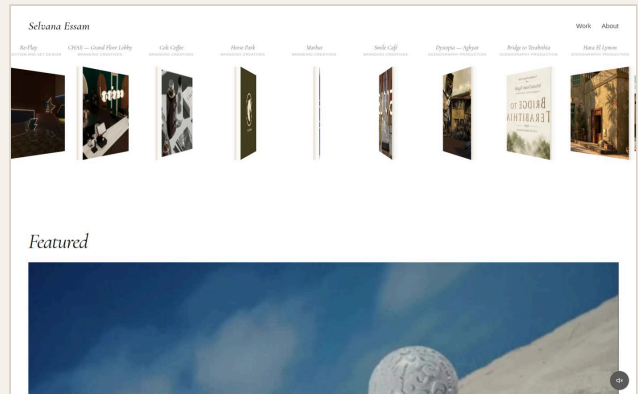
The site was visited the way a normal person would: on a laptop and on a phone, without knowing anything about her, from the homepage through About and three projects.



The first screen is a white page. The stage photo appears only after scrolling.

WHAT WORKS

- **The stage photo is excellent.** A woman in a gold dress on a red-curtained stage says “theatre, drama, set design” before you read a word.
- **The look fits her:** elegant italic type, white space, calm colours. Nothing feels cheap or template-like.
- **The project pages are the strongest part.** Smile Café shows how she thinks, not just the result.
- **The About page builds trust:** real jobs with dates, education, skills and software.
- **Three clear categories** of work.
- **Contact is easy** once you find it.



The rotating 3D carousel shows the work as thin slivers, some of them backwards.

WHY SOME OF IT MATTERS

People judge a site in the first few seconds and rarely give it a second chance. A portfolio is also a sample of how carefully someone works: small mistakes on her own site make a client wonder how careful she'll be with theirs.

The issues on the next page are listed in the order a visitor meets them.

Ten things that get in the way

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- 01 **The first screen is a plain white page.** The stage photo only appears after scrolling, and many visitors decide in about three seconds whether to stay.

 - 02 **The top bar overlaps the content.** It has no background, so its letters collide with the page on every screen, including mobile. It reads like a bug.

 - 03 **The 3D carousel hides the work.** Projects appear as thin turning cards, and some show their back side, so “Bridge to Terabithia” reads backwards.

 - 04 **Names don’t match.** “Branding & Creative Direction” in one place is “Branding creatives” in another; “Scenography & Spatial Design” becomes “SCENOGRAPHY Production”. There are typos such as “CHAI”, and Smile Café’s logo says “Smile Line”.

 - 05 **There’s no “work with me” moment.** The only invitation is “Get in touch” at the very bottom, with icons and no visible email.

 - 06 **“Featured” shows a single project.** A whole section for one item feels empty.

 - 07 **The About photo cuts off her face.** The crop is in the photo itself, so it needs a new portrait or a different crop.

 - 08 **The site is heavy: 14–17 MB for the homepage** (40 files). The main photo alone is 2 MB and images are requested at 3840 px. On normal Egyptian mobile data many visitors will wait or leave.

 - 09 **The small grey labels are very faint** and hard to read, especially on phones.

 - 10 **Image files named “ChatGPT_Image...”** appear on three projects (Haret El Lamoun, Haret El Ghagar, Re-Play). If a client notices, it can hurt trust in a set designer’s portfolio.
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“The homepage tries hard to be artistic and forgets to say plainly: this is what I do, and here’s how to hire me.”

Nine roles, *each with its own question*

A portfolio is read by very different people. An engineer sees what breaks; a recruiter sees what a CV claims; a café owner sees whether she can deliver their project. So the new site was reviewed from each of these points of view, in two rounds, in a real browser on laptop and phone.

ROLE	WHAT THEY LOOK FOR	WHY THIS ROLE
Front-end engineer ROUND 1 · HOW IT'S BUILT	Bugs, broken links, what happens with fast clicks, the back button, slow connections.	A beautiful site that breaks once loses the visitor's trust immediately.
UI designer ROUND 1	Hierarchy, typography, spacing, cropping, anything that looks cheap or busy.	For a visual creative, the site <i>is</i> the first piece in the portfolio.
Motion designer ROUND 1	Timing, easing, effects competing with each other, what to cut.	The curtain and spotlight are central to the idea, so they must feel crafted, not gimmicky.
Accessibility & UX specialist ROUND 1	Contrast, keyboard use, screen readers, tap sizes, motion settings (WCAG 2.2).	Many visitors have low vision, use a keyboard or prefer less motion, and some companies check this.
Performance engineer ROUND 1	Page weight, load time, smoothness on a mid-range Android phone on mobile data.	Most of her audience in Egypt and the Gulf will open it on a phone.
Hiring manager ROUND 2 · HOW PEOPLE TAKE IT IN	An executive creative director at a Cairo/Dubai agency: interview, maybe, or pass?	Agencies are one of the two ways she gets work: a job.
Recruiter ROUND 2	A 30-second screen: which roles, which companies, any red flags in the CV?	Recruiters decide who even reaches the hiring manager.
Brand owner ROUND 2	A café founder with a real budget: could she do my project, and how do I contact her?	Clients are the other way she gets work: a commission.
Cognitive & UX psychologist ROUND 2	First impressions, trust, comfort, attention and the emotional arc of a visit.	Explains <i>why</i> people react the way they do, and what makes them feel safe enough to reach out.

Each review followed a written brief for that role and was checked against the live pages, with measurements where possible (contrast ratios, file sizes, frame rates).

The look was right. *The details weren't yet.*

The first round reviewed the first version of the new design. It found the layout calm and well judged, and a set of bugs, heavy files and accessibility gaps to fix before anyone outside sees it.

Front-end engineer

6 SERIOUS BUGS, ALL REPRODUCED

- The Work and Contact links could land in the wrong place on the page.
- Clicking twice quickly during a page change could show one page with another's address.
- "Skip to content" opened a "page not found".
- If the smooth-scroll script was slow to arrive, the whole site waited for it: 8 seconds in the test.

WHY IT MATTERS

These are the moments when a visitor decides a site is "broken" and leaves.

UI designer

"THE LAYOUT IS CALM AND WELL JUDGED"

- What looked cheap was the content, not the design: galleries were raw presentation slides with text cut mid-word and repeated covers.
- The Bridge to Terabithia cover was the university title card, which reads as a student submission.
- About twelve different title sizes instead of a few.
- The curtain texture was blurry and the wrong red.

WHY IT MATTERS

For a visual creative, a single weak image costs more than ten good ones earn.

Motion designer

"CUT, THEN ADD ONE MOMENT"

- The intro counter looked like a loading bar and replayed on every visit.
- Too many effects competed: tilting previews, blurred letters, a large cursor ring.
- The image viewer showed a second of black before the photo.
- Missing: one continuous movement, the project title carried through the curtain into the page.

WHY IT MATTERS

One crafted movement feels expensive. Many small ones feel like a template.

Accessibility & UX specialist

WCAG 2.2 · LAPTOP, PHONE, 200% ZOOM

- Screen readers spelled names letter by letter: “S e l v a n a”.
- Pressing Tab moved into a hidden menu, so the focus disappeared.
- Some text was far too faint: dimmed list titles at 2.0:1 and photo captions at 1.5:1, where 4.5:1 is the minimum.
- Films played with no way to pause; buttons were as small as 22 px on phones.
- Project pages ended with no way to get in touch.

WHY IT MATTERS

Readable, usable sites feel more professional to everyone, and some companies check accessibility formally.

Performance engineer

MID-RANGE ANDROID · MOBILE DATA

- The homepage was already light: about 0.5 MB on the first screen and 0.8 MB fully scrolled on a phone.
- But on project pages every image loaded at once. Bridge to Terabithia downloaded all 39 images (4 MB) before the visitor scrolled.
- LAVERN's four films added up to about 16 MB on a phone.
- The stage effects kept the processor busy even when nothing was moving.

WHY IT MATTERS

Slow pages cost visitors before they see a single project, and drain phone batteries.

ALL FIXED

Every bug, speed and accessibility issue above was fixed without changing the look. Bridge to Terabithia now loads 2 images up front instead of 39, and the animation stops completely when nothing moves.

ONE DELIBERATE EXCEPTION

The accessibility specialist suggested going back to the normal mouse pointer. The custom cursor was kept as a design choice, but it switches off on phones, in text fields and when a visitor prefers less motion.

Would they *hire her*?

The second round asked a different question: not whether the site works, but whether the right people understand it, trust it and act on it.

Hiring manager

EXECUTIVE CREATIVE DIRECTOR · CAIRO / DUBAI AGENCY

| *“The first full screen is her, in a gown, on a stage. I learn that she performs before I learn what she makes.”*

- At three minutes: “genuinely talented, early in her career.”
- The strongest thing on the site, COLT’s 3D render next to the built drive-thru, sat about 7,000 pixels down the page.
- Missing on every project: client, year, location, built or not, team size, result.

VERDICT

Leaning interview, for a **senior art director** role (spatial and set). The titles run ahead of the evidence shown, so the proof should come first.

Recruiter

CREATIVE TALENT · EGYPT AND THE GULF

- An interesting mix that sells: real shoots, 3D (3ds Max, V-Ray, Unreal), live visuals (TouchDesigner, Resolume, MadMapper) and café brand-to-space work.
- Titles like “Creative Director, 2020–now” next to a 2026 degree raise questions; honest titles such as “Founder & Creative Lead” earn more trust.
- “Download CV” opened the print dialog, and the printed CV left out her email and phone.

VERDICT

“Yes.” Would put her forward to production houses, experiential agencies, scenic studios and hospitality design studios in Cairo, Riyadh and Dubai.

Brand owner

FOUNDER · OPENING A SPECIALTY CAFÉ

“Two screens in and I still haven’t seen a coffee cup.”

- Could she do my café? “Probably yes, and COLT Coffee is the reason.” The built drive-thru is exactly the brief, but it was buried in small grey type.
- Couldn’t tell paid client work from student work.
- Would contact her on **WhatsApp**, which was only at the very bottom of the page.

VERDICT

“**Yes, I’d reach out, because of COLT.**” The theatre is “charming once”; after that it should step aside for the work.

Cognitive & UX psychologist

FIRST IMPRESSIONS · TRUST · COMFORT

- **First impressions form in a fraction of a second** (the “50 ms” studies). The gown on stage makes people think “performer” before they read the small line underneath.
- **The peak-end rule:** people remember the strongest moment and the last one. The peak was her in the spotlight, so they remembered her, not her work. And a closed curtain with no text reads as “the show is over”, so some visitors simply left there.
- **Comfort comes from control.** A long intro that blocks scrolling, and text that only lights up as you scroll, take control away.
- **Cultural fit:** WhatsApp was nearly hidden and there was almost no Arabic, for an audience in Egypt and the Gulf.

VERDICT

The beauty creates goodwill (the “aesthetic-usability effect”). Turn that goodwill into belief: make the curtain an invitation, put proof first and make contact effortless.

Four different readers, *the same six points*

Each second-round reviewer worked alone, yet their conclusions lined up closely. That agreement is the strongest reason for the changes that followed.

“A performer.”

The first impression is the gown and the stage, not the work. The role and clients must be readable in the first five seconds.

The best proof is buried.

COLT’s render next to the real, built drive-thru convinces everyone. It should be the first thing they see.

Student work looks like client work.

Both are valuable, but they should be labelled so a client knows what was paid and built.

The closed curtain ends the show.

A curtain with nothing on it says “goodbye”. It should say “come in, here is the work”.

Facts beat titles.

Client, city, year and “built” earn more trust than big job titles. Honest titles read as more senior, not less.

WhatsApp is hidden.

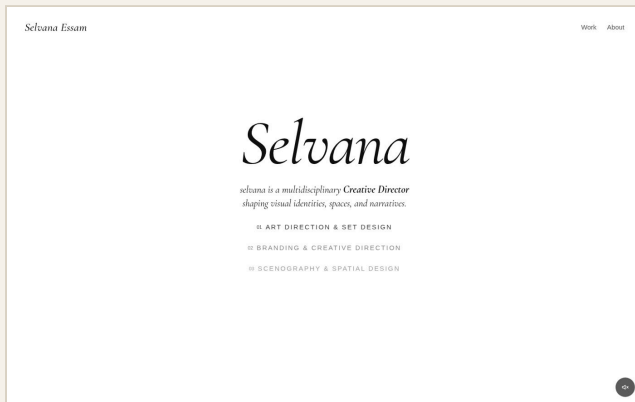
In Egypt and the Gulf it’s how people actually reach out, so it should be one tap away on every page.

Every change has *a reason*

PROBLEM	WHAT CHANGED	RAISED BY
White first screen; role hard to see	The stage is the first screen, and in five seconds it says: <i>Selvana Essam · Creative direction, branding & set design · For brands, campaigns and spaces · Alexandria, Egypt · COLT Coffee · Horse Park · Marbat · CHAI.</i>	First review, psychologist, hiring manager
Closed curtain reads as “the end”	As the curtains close, “Act II · The work ↓” appears on them and leads straight into the projects.	Psychologist
Best proof buried	Built and shot client work comes first: COLT Coffee, Closer, LAVERN. COLT shows its 3D render beside the built drive-thru.	Hiring manager, brand owner
Missing facts	Every project has a facts line: client · city · year · built, shot or concept. Unknown facts show as a marked “Year?” instead of a guess.	All four, round 2
Student work mixed with client work	Every project is labelled Client , Concept or Study . Bridge to Terabithia is presented as a graduation project.	Recruiter, brand owner
Galleries were raw slides	5–12 chosen images per project, in one consistent shape; plans shown on paper.	UI designer, hiring manager
Carousel hid the work	A clear list of every project with a preview, filterable by Set design, Branding or Scenography.	First review
No way to get in touch	WhatsApp and email in the menu, footer and on every page, a floating WhatsApp button on phones, and “Let’s make something.” at the end of each project.	First review, brand owner, accessibility
Almost no Arabic	Arabic project names written in Aref Ruqaa, and تواصل عبر واتساب at the contact block.	Psychologist
Intro too long, every visit	The full curtain intro plays once per visit, a short one after that, and any scroll or key skips it. No counter.	Motion designer, psychologist, performance
Busy, competing effects	One quiet style. One signature movement: the project’s title glides from the curtain into the page.	Motion designer
CV opened a print dialog	A real one-page A4 PDF with email, phone and Instagram.	Recruiter, accessibility
14–17 MB, slow on phones	Images sized to the screen and loaded as you scroll; films only play when visible; about 0.5 MB on first view.	First review, performance
Bugs and accessibility gaps	All reproduced bugs fixed; readable contrast; keyboard and screen-reader support; 44 px tap targets; a Motion on/off switch.	Engineer, accessibility
Inconsistent names and typos	One name per discipline everywhere; spellings corrected and listed for her to confirm.	First review

Same person, same work, *clearer story*

BEFORE



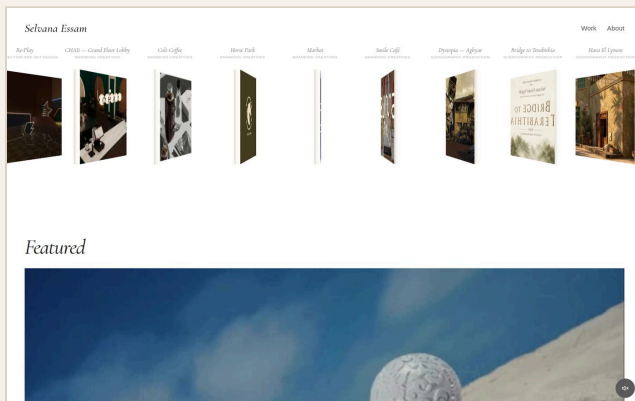
First screen: white, with small grey text.

AFTER



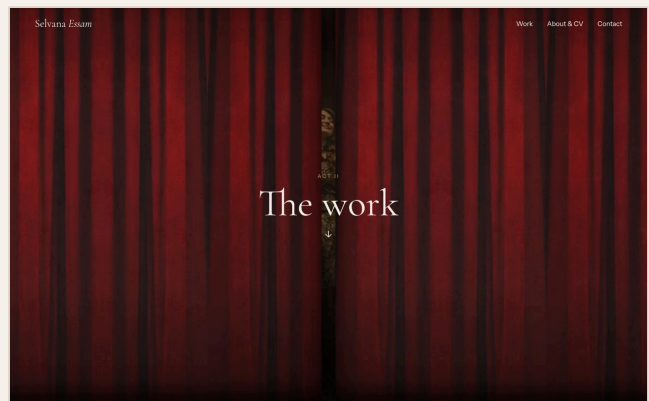
The stage, her role, who it's for, and her clients.

BEFORE



Work as thin rotating cards.

AFTER



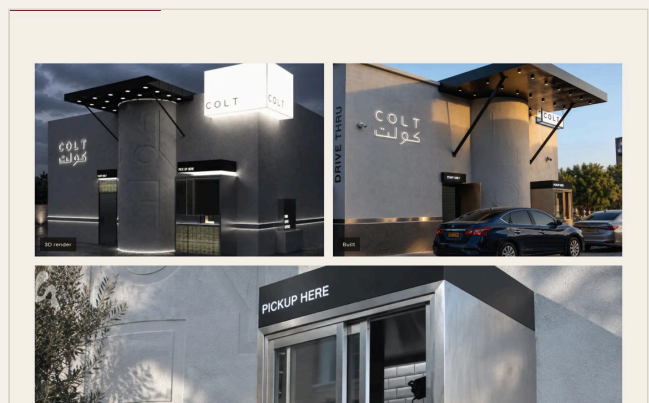
The curtain closes and invites you into the work.

BEFORE



Project page: long text, no facts, no contact.

AFTER



COLT: the 3D render next to the built drive-thru.

Ten answers *finish the site*

Nothing on the new site was invented. Where a fact is missing, it shows as a marked placeholder. These answers fill them in and remove the last doubts the reviewers raised.

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- 1 **For each project:** client name, city, year, and whether it was built, launched or shot. Who else was on the team, and what was your exact part?

 - 2 **Job titles:** is “Creative Director & Partner, Vana Creative Studio” right? Would “Founder & Creative Lead” describe it better? The same for Vana Room and Bab Ashra.

 - 3 **LAVERN or LAVERNE?** The bottles say LAVERNE. And what is “Atlantis Homme”?

 - 4 **AI-assisted images:** the files named “ChatGPT_Image...” (Haret El Lamoun, Haret El Ghagar, Re-Play) should be labelled honestly, for example “modelled in 3ds Max, atmosphere AI-assisted”, or replaced.

 - 5 **Availability:** open to freelance, full-time, relocation (Riyadh, Dubai), remote 3D work? A LinkedIn link and an email on your own domain help recruiters.

 - 6 **Your name in Arabic,** spelled the way you write it.

 - 7 **A photo of you at work** on a set or site, and one or two short quotes from clients.

 - 8 **English level:** keep “upper-intermediate”, or use “professional working proficiency”?

 - 9 **Spellings changed** from the current site: CHAli → CHAI, Hara El Lymon → Haret El Lamoun, Hara El Ghagar → Haret El Ghagar, and Smile Café or “Smile Line”?

 - 10 **WhatsApp:** is +20 150 100 3126 the number to use?